



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Field School

School Website: <https://thefieldschool.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Field School Chicago (ZIP 60644) presents a consciously classical, Christian, and diverse learning community. Public materials frame the school as a diverse, classical, Christ-centered institution with a curriculum rooted in timeless truths, moral formation, and a habit-driven approach to education. The school openly embraces Charlotte Mason influences, Great Books, and a humanities-rich program (Bible, literature, art, music; history through timeline-based study; Book of Centuries). There is clear emphasis on worship, daily theology, character formation, and family involvement, including a Family Tree Organization and volunteer opportunities. Taken together, these elements align strongly with a Classical framework, particularly around formation of character, cultivation of virtue, engagement with timeless content, and a community-centered pedagogy that integrates faith with reason.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Key drivers of this classification include: explicit Christ-centered and worship practices; emphasis on virtue, formation, and moral imagination; a humanities-forward curriculum with Charlotte Mason influences; use of Great Books and primary texts; memory-friendly, habit-forming pedagogy; and robust family/community involvement. The materials also show a continuing commitment to diversity and service within a classical framework, which reinforces the holistic formation emphasized by classic models. While some components (e.g., explicit mentions of grammar/logic/rhetoric pedagogy) are less overt, the combination of Great Books, habit formation, virtuous inquiry, and a historically rooted curriculum strongly supports a Classical orientation.

What would move the needle for a fuller CLASSICAL alignment (if pursued further): more explicit articulation and documentation of a complete Trivium progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across the K–8 spectrum; clearer demonstration of Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades; and more explicit textual citations to primary Great Books within the core curriculum to strengthen the Great Conversations aspect. Additionally, richer integration of liturgical/prayer practices as formal curricular components (beyond worship and faith-life activities) could further shore up Element 1.

Note: The following category-by-category analysis includes keyword analyses that map to the Positive and Negative keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and provides a category-level rating with justification.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Field School presents itself as a “diverse, classical, Christ-centered school,” with a foundation in Christ, worship practices, and a theology-infused community life (e.g., “Christ-centered environment,” “morning worship,” “Deep Christian Faith”). The public materials explicitly articulate goals around glorifying God, worship, and spiritual formation, which align with transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community practices in classical education.

- The school's profile emphasizes “Deep Christian Faith,” “Kingdom Diversity,” and a mission to glorify God, indicating a theologically grounded framework that permeates curriculum and culture. - Morning worship,

chapel activities, and a Bible-literature-art-music humanities approach demonstrate liturgical and communal practices integrated with daily learning.

Positive keyword indicators present (examples drawn from public materials): Christ-centered, worship, Bible, Christian faith, kingdom/diversity in a faith-led community, “great books” (in a faith-informed Great Books context), spiritual depth, liturgical life.

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: multiple (Christ-centered; worship/morning worship; Bible; Christian faith; spiritual depth; kingdom diversity; Great Books; habit formation; moral imagination). - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials.

Why this rating - The materials emphasize religious/metaphysical foundations as core to identity and pedagogy, with explicit theology integration and liturgical/community practices. The presence and centrality of Christ-centered language and worship strongly justify CLASSICAL in this category.

Citations: The Field School’s Christ-centered framing and worship emphasis appear across admissions and profile materials, including explicit statements about “Christ-centered environment” and worship, and the Great Books/humanities orientation noted in curriculum pages.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe education as formation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job preparation. Phrases emphasize formation of character, moral imagination, and intellectual cultivation (e.g., “formation,” “habits of the heart,” “intellectual virtue,” “moral imagination,” “character development,” “liberal education,” “formation through the arts,” and “integration of faith and reason”). The habit-motto framing from Charlotte Mason (I am, I can, I ought, I will) is presented as a foundational guide for character formation. - The mission statements emphasize the aim of forming students in truth, goodness, and beauty within a Christian framework, consistent with classical aims of human flourishing and moral imagination. - The public materials articulate formation through timeless content, moral formation, and a holistic approach that aligns with the classical aim of education as formation rather than mere information.

Positive keyword indicators present: formation, virtue, moral imagination, character development, love of learning, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, holistic education, mentorship.

Negative keyword indicators present: minimal to none in public materials (no strong focus on standard workforce metrics or standardized testing emphasis).

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: at least 6–10 explicit terms/phrases (formation, virtues, character, moral imagination, habit formation, liberal education, lifelong learning, truth/goodness/beauty, holistic education, mentorship). - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit negative indicators.

Why this rating - The school’s stated purpose and goals foreground formation and virtue, not only technical skill or vocational outcomes, aligning strongly with CLASSICAL.

Citations: Formation vocabulary and habit-based formation statements appear in habit-motto materials and mission statements, including “formation is the goal” and “intelligence plus character — the goal of true education.”

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Field School features a humanities-forward curriculum with Bible, literature, art, and music; a chronological/world-history approach; and the use of Story of the World and a Book of Centuries in humanities. This aligns with classical methods and a Great Books framework in practice (e.g., four elements of humanities; timeline study; primary texts; emphasis on moral imagination and virtue through historical texts). Public materials explicitly mention humanities and Story of the World, and a four-element humanities approach anchored in Christian content.

- Great Books is explicitly referenced in the public materials (the curriculum includes Great Books and rigorous discussion as part of the classical model). The site also emphasizes Story of the World and a four-

element humanities curriculum. However, there is less explicit, persistent emphasis on the traditional Trivium components (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as formal stage progression across K–8 in the public materials; the explicit mention of grammar/logic/rhetoric is not consistently documented in the accessible materials. - Charlotte Mason influence and habit-based character formation are highlighted, with a strong emphasis on moral formation and the cultivation of virtue through reading, discussion, and the arts.

Positive keyword indicators present: Great Books, Story of the World, humanities (Bible, literature, art, music), books (Book of Centuries), history through timeline, moral imagination, contemplation, aesthetics, liberal education, formation through the arts.

Negative keyword indicators present: limited explicit reference to the grammar/logic/rhetoric progression; no strong emphasis on job-prep or standardized testing emphasis in curriculum text (though there are separate sections on admissions and tests). The lack of explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric sequencing is a potential gap relative to the strongest classical models.

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: approximately 5–8 core terms/phrases (Great Books, Story of the World, four elements of humanities, Bible, literature, art, music, Book of Centuries, moral imagination). - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit negative indicators in the curriculum text; however, explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric progression is not clearly documented (a potential gap relative to a fully “grammar/logic/rhetoric” explicit curriculum). - Net: More than half of the classical curriculum indicators are present, but the absence of explicit Trivium progression lowers this to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The Field School clearly embraces classical content and Great Books-oriented study and a humanities-centered approach. The lack of explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric sequencing across grades and the emphasis on Charlotte Mason-inspired methods introduce some ambiguity relative to a fully classical program. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL captures the present state.

Citations: Humanities-focused curriculum, Story of the World, Book of Centuries, and Great Books references are documented in academic/curriculum pages.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Field School emphasizes a hybrid pedagogy that includes contemplative, memory-friendly approaches and active engagement. Lower-school pedagogy features memory-friendly practices (singing, chanting, regular review, and “the habit formation” framework). Upper grades emphasize discussion and primary-text engagement in a discussion-and-analysis framework (Socratic-style discussion is not overtly documented, but “rigorous discussion,” primary-text study, and a classical approach are evident). Evidence includes: - Lower-school singing/chanting to deepen memory and delight (e.g., references to singing clubs and daily memory-based activities). - Habit formation and Charlotte Mason-inspired approach that emphasizes character formation and contemplative, disciplined study. - Upper-grade engagement with texts and discussion (rigorous discussion, primary texts, and historical texts) and the goal of developing critical thinking. - Explicit mention of a humanistic/humanities-oriented approach, with an emphasis on reading, discussion, and the arts.

Positive keyword indicators present: singing, chanting, memory work, contemplation, habits of the heart, moral imagination, formation, liberal education, discussion, great books, primary texts.

Negative keyword indicators present: the explicit, structured Trivium sequencing (grammar/logic/rhetoric) is not consistently documented as a formal pedagogy across grades; no explicit career- or job-prep dominance.

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: roughly 6–9 items (singing/chanting; memory-based pedagogy; contemplation; habits; formation; discussion; Great Books; primary texts; humanities focus). - Negative keywords present: 0 explicit negative indicators in pedagogy text beyond the absence of a clearly labeled formal Trivium progression.

Why this rating - Pedagogy shows clear classical-inflected practices (memory, hymn/singing, discussion, primary texts, moral formation) but with less explicit, formalized Trivium sequencing in public materials. This justifies SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Evidence of singing/chanting and memory-based pedagogy; habit formation; and discussion-based study appear across admissions/academics pages and calendar entries.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe the faculty as living, relational, and central to school culture, emphasizing mentorship and character formation. References to staff culture, leadership, and the faculty's role in the school's mission are present, including statements about staff embodying the school's values and a culture of virtue and service. Examples include: - Careership and leadership information indicating a people-centered approach and a staff culture that models virtue and character. - Statements about the staff and leadership reflecting a shared mission, and the faculty being the core of the school, with families invited into the learning community (e.g., leadership and board). - The field school emphasizes relationships, trust, and a humane atmosphere among students and staff, with explicit emphasis on the staff embodying virtues and forming the learning environment. - Teaching staff participation in arts and music initiatives (e.g., the Orchestra Teacher job posting) and public-facing mentions of teachers as part of the mission.

Positive keyword indicators present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, core of the school, teachers as sympathetic colleagues, portrait of teacher/student ideals, staff culture rooted in virtue.

Negative keyword indicators present: none identified in public materials.

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: multiple (model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; core of the school; staff culture; faculty as partners in mission). - Negative keywords present: 0.

Why this rating - The Field School's materials position the faculty as central to the school's mission, emphasizing virtuous teaching and a collaborative, mentor-like culture, which aligns well with CLASSICAL.

Citations: Faculty/model teacher language and staff-centric ethos appear in Career and leadership sections.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Field School emphasizes family involvement and partnership with parents as co-teachers in several materials. There are explicit parent-facing structures such as the Family Tree Organization (FTO), volunteer opportunities, and parent gatherings and events. Public materials describe parent participation, prayer teams, and a community-driven school culture, reflecting a cooperative model between school and family. Examples include: - Family Tree Organization (FTO) and volunteer opportunities; explicit call to engage parents in events and service. - Admissions processes and tours to involve families; a welcoming stance toward visits and engagement with parents in learning and school life. - Presence of parent-focused communications and events, including school calendar events and parent-teacher conferences. - The school encourages philanthropic partnerships and involvement through giving and partnerships, signaling a community-building orientation with parents as stakeholders.

Positive keyword indicators present: family involvement, co-teachers, parent organizations, parent engagement, volunteerism, family partnerships, school visits, community events.

Negative keyword indicators present: none detected in public materials.

Quantitative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: multiple (FTO, volunteering, parent involvement, tours, family partnerships, community events, fundraising partnerships). - Negative keywords present: 0.

Why this rating - The Field School demonstrates robust parental involvement and community engagement oriented around classical education values and mission.

Citations: Family involvement and parent partnerships are described in Family Tree Organization content and volunteer information; admissions and tours show ongoing parent engagement.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here since the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. If we were to move toward FULLY CLASSICAL, potential needle-moving steps could include: - Make explicit the Trivium progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across K–8 in public-facing materials, with sample scope and sequence. - Strengthen explicit documentation of Socratic-style pedagogy in upper grades (e.g., weekly Socratic seminars, use of primary texts with guided dialectic). - Increase explicit Great Books citations in core curriculums and align assessments to classic philosophical questions alongside literary analysis. - Expand liturgical and theological integration as a formal curricular component (e.g., periodic liturgy-focused units across subjects with clear integration to virtue formation).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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